

FIRST CONGREGATIONAL CHURCH
of Los Angeles

The Grateful Life ~ Pay Attention
9 November 2025



Landscape with Yellow Birds
Artwork by Paul Klee, 1923

540 S. Commonwealth Avenue, Los Angeles, California 90020
Telephone 213.385.1341 – www.FCCLA.org

Childcare & Children's Programming at First Church

FCCLA offers childcare and children's programming during service for all ages — from infants through youth. For more information or to register your child, please stop by the First Kids First check-in table in the entrance to the Cathedral, or follow the signs in the hallway through the middle doors of the Sanctuary.

The Gathering of the People

First Congregational Church of Los Angeles is a safe place for all people, and we celebrate our diversity of race, creed, age, ability, gender, religion, cultural background, sexual orientation, gender identities and expressions...

We extend a warm welcome to all this morning and especially those who are with us for the first time. Your presence both enriches us and this time of celebration together ~

Please note that our services are live streamed at fccla.org/live.

Organ Prelude Concert

Dr. Christoph Bull, Organist-in-Residence

Improvisation on MERLE'S TUNE and NETTLETON

A Close Path (Saginaw Rozzo) and Improvisation

Fantasia (Georg Philipp Telemann)

"Chant de la Creuse" and "Maestoso in D Major" from *L'Organiste* (César Franck) and Improvisation

Wachet auf ruft uns die Stimme, BWV 645 (Johann Sebastian Bach)

Prelude on FOREST GREEN (Carlos Staszkeski) and Improvisation

Chiming of the Hour

Welcome

Rev. Laura Vail Fregin

Words of Gathering

Rev. Fregin & Rev. Michael Schiefelbein

In the midst of our everyday
we often miss the signs of the sacred –
the smile we didn't expect,
the outreached hand that checked our fall,
the frustrating thing that happened
that kept us from doing
what we *really* wanted to do.

We look back on our days,
eager to find the presence
of a Holiness that guides us.
Yet, the more we seek to understand,
the more we seem to stand on shifting ground.

We need courage to travel this ground that demands
we pay attention to our lives,
our relationships, and our faith, even to the point
that we be but left with grains of sand,
slipping through our fingers.

*On this day, may we know such courage,
may we find celebration in the simple truth that we are here,
and may we live this day, and every day,
in thanksgiving for the presence of the Holy.* [adapt/gvosper]

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us!

Please stand as you are able, in body or in spirit, for our Hymn of Gathering

***Hymn of Gathering** *In the Midst of All Our Living*

NETTLETON

In the midst of every blessing may my heart be filled with grace.
Streams of goodness, ever flowing call for songs of highest praise.
May my words be filled with gratitude; may my glad heart humble be.
As a holder of a blessing may I share it gratefully.

In the midst of every trial may my heart be filled with grace.
Streams of comfort, ever flowing call for songs of highest praise.
May I find the strength within me; may I sense it everywhere.
As I face what must be handled may I find truth I can share.

In the midst of all our living may our hearts be filled with grace.
Streams of goodness ever flowing call for songs of highest praise.
May we seek and find encouragement; may our choices worthy be.
As we journey on together, may we know integrity.

-Words @ Scott Kearns 2008, inspired by Robert Robinson, 1758

***Prayer of Awareness**

Rev. Fregin

O God, on this morning,
we take these moments to sense our oneness.
Our roots push far into the soil
and we find ourselves deeply connected
with all that is and was and yet shall be.
May our experience of what we do here this day,
what we see and what we hear,
so affect us, that we walk from this place
in awe of our deepest connections
and to this life we share.

*From the depths of our common hope, we pray.
Amen and Amen.*

***Introit**

"Create In Me A Clean Heart"
Cathedral Choir

HEALY WILLAN

***The Lord's Prayer**

Rev. Schiefelbein

*Great Spirit, our Creator, who is in all places,
Sacred is your name.
May your wisdom guide us,
Your will be done in our lives, as it is throughout Creation.*

*Provide for us today the nourishment we need,
And forgive us our wrongs, as we forgive those who have wronged us.*

*Lead us on the path of understanding and respect,
And protect us from ignorance and harm.*

*For you are the source of all power, beauty, and love,
From generation to generation, forever and always. Amen.*

***Gloria Deo**

Glory be to God, and to the Christ and to the Holy Ghost,
As it was in the beginning, is now and ever shall be.
World without end, Amen, Amen.

***Passing of the Peace**

Rev. Fregin

In these days...
May we find and follow
the rhythms that bring us life.
May we let go of the patterns
that confine and constrain.
May our turning and returning
trace pathways of peace,
as each grateful step we take
make a life-giving way.
[adpt/jrichardson]

This morning, may the Peace of God be with you.
And also with you!

You are invited to share this ancient greeting with a bow.

Please be seated

Reading from Our Religious Tradition *from the Gospel of Luke, Chapter 12*

Rev. Schiefelbein

For the Word of God in Scripture,
for the Word of God in Nature,
for the Word of God among and within us.
Thanks be to God!

Prayers with the People

Rev. Fregin

Invitation to Silence and Prayer

Silence

Prayer of Our Hearts

Eternal Mystery, Sacred Presence,
Breath within our breath, Song within the silence,
we open our hearts
to your Holy Mystery alive among us here.

Each one of us brings colors to this day's creation—
our hopes and doubts,
our joys and weariness,
our longings and our love.
Together, we paint the sky of this moment in time.

*May the beauty of life's fullness awaken within us,
loosening the grasp of the ordinary,
and lifting our spirits toward wonder.*

May the vastness of mystery expand our minds,
that we might release our craving for certainty
and rest in the grace of unknowing.

*May the light of new possibilities dawn among us,
that faith may unfold like wings,
lifting us into a world transformed
by compassion, imagination, and hope.*

And when we look upon the skies we have painted together,
may we see the shared beauty of creation,
and the miracle of our being here, now,
woven into the divine tapestry of all that is.

*We pray all this as those who seek to journey
in the way of the One who forever shows us the path of love and gratitude.*

This morning, may it be so.
*May it be so for all of us, O God.
Amen and Amen.*

Meditation Anthem

"The Gift"
Cathedral Choir

RUSSELL WALLACE

Sermon

The Grateful Life ~ Pay Attention

Rev. Michael Lehman

The Eucharist and Blessings

Rev. Fregin & Rev. Lehman

Words of Invitation and Remembrance

We have lovingly been called to be a people of God.
Having been given this bread and cup as a reminder of God's love,
we now listen for God's presence in silence and in sound –
we listen in the voices of all people,
we listen to the music of creation,
and in this way, we are reconnected to God
through this holy meal.
In this time may we hear the voice
that calls us home to our Creator, Christ, and Spirit.

We remember the stories of Jesus,
the one who did not have a house of their own,

and yet found home whenever they came to the table with their friends.
To help them remember God's great love for them,
Jesus would take the bread, hold it up for all to see,
and say, 'When you eat this, remember the love with which it is given.'

And then, Jesus would take a cup of the fruit of the vine,
pouring it out for all of them to see and saying,
'This cup is poured out for you – remember the love
that you are now called to give.'

Prayer of Blessing

God of fresh bread and newly harvested fruit of the vine,
we sense your presentness among us
in grace-filled moments of sharing,
in carefully created communities of loving solidarity,
in holy times of birthing new life
from the renewing of our minds.

*We delight in the moving of your steadfast Spirit
that calls us to find water for the thirsty,
invites us to prepare meals
for all who hunger, and
give us the gifts to welcome all in our midst.*

May it ever be so.
Amen and Amen.

Sharing of the Bread and the Cup

At this table we celebrate all the diverse ways we have been created. Everyone is invited to share in this feast. This morning we will receive communion with gluten free wafers and grape juice. You are invited to come forward to receive these gifts and then light a candle to signify the prayers of your heart on this day. As we share this time, we remember that this is the bread of new life and the cup of hope, given in love for each of us.

Invitation to Generosity

Rev. Schiefelbein

At First Church, we consider every pledge, tithe, offering and contribution a gift for the life of our community of faith. No matter how they're given, our gifts show gratitude. You are invited to visit our website at fccla.org/give. Our hospitality team will also bring baskets for your in-person gifts during the Offertory.

Offertory

"Birdsong"

HEATHER MASSE, arr. DAVID HARRIS

Laurel Irene, Molly Pease, Tiffany Ho, and David Harris

***Doxology**

From all that dwell below the skies,
let the Creator's praise arise!
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Your name shall sound and praises soar
till suns shall rise and set no more.
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Alleluia! Alleluia! Alleluia!

[adapt/Isaac Watts, 1719]

***Prayer of Offering**

Rev. Schiefelbein

Holy One,
when given pause to truly see this world,
we stand in awe of its beauty.
When truly hearing words
that share us with another's heart,
we stand amazed at the diversity of humanity.
When time allows
and our thoughts travel deep into our own souls,
a wordless place of images and dreams,
we stand within Holiness and we are blessed.

With hope, we greeted this time together
as one in which all this might happen,
and, with blessing, make us feel at home.

*So now, Holy One,
with these gifts we thank you,
for these blessed and beautiful moments.
Amen and Amen.*

Please be seated

Life at First Church

Rev. Fregin & Rev. Lehman

Words of Blessing

Rev. Lehman

The blessings of heaven,
the blessings of earth,
the blessings of sea and of sky.
On those we love this day
and on every human family
the gifts of heaven,
the gifts of earth,
the gifts of sea and sky.
[jphilipnewell]
Amen! May it be so!

Choral Response

"Wachet Auf"
Cathedral Choir

J.S. BACH

*"Gloria we sing with all our voices. No eye has ever seen,
no ear has ever heard the joy we know. Our praises flow to God."*

***Hymn for the Journey**

As Grain on Scattered Hillsides

MERLE'S TUNE

As grain on scattered hillsides, when gathered, makes one bread,
God, gather all your people as one in Christ our head.
We come from many places, and we are not the same,
Yet your strong love has called us to meet in your name.

A grain of wheat is fruitless until in earth it lies;
Then, dying to its old life, it bears and multiplies.
So may we die to hatred, to all our hurtful ways,
Reborn to common living, to love, to work, to praise.

Like yeast that brings new ferment so lifeless dough may rise,
Your Spirit is the leaven of life that satisfies.
As salt enhances flavor, enriches, and preserves,
May earth rejoice to savor a church that heals and serves.

O Christ, the new creation; O Spirit, filled with peace,
Come now and move among us; make us a sign of love.
Come, knead and blend each texture with strong and gentle hands,
That we may be one body, one loaf in many lands.

Please be seated for the Postlude

Postlude

Dr. Christoph Bull, Organist-in-Residence

Prelude on FOREST GREEN - Reprise (Carlos Staszkeski)

Inside The Music

"As we celebrate Native American Heritage Month, I wanted to share one of my favorite pieces by a living indigenous composer; Russell Wallace's "The Gift." I've been reflecting a lot on what it means to sing music from different cultures. Wallace has given us the gift of sheet music and a recording. With these, we can begin to enter into the ceremonial space he has created with his music. The indigenous composers I am grateful to call my friends are careful to avoid sharing the traditional music of their people with the general public. Those songs are specific to ceremony, to a people, and often to a task. They were not written for concerts, church services, or casual singing. Like my friends, Wallace is careful with those lines. He has, however, created ceremonial music that is new with the intent to share with others. Music like "The Gift" is intended for us. He wrote it in community, and intentionally shared it with the broader public so that we might feel the warmth and delight of shared community through song. By doing so, he creates portals for different people to connect across time and place. In his introduction to the score he writes:

"This song is about a community coming together to prepare a feast - to celebrate "the gift" of traditions and the transmission of knowledge. A traditional song will have a certain name or title, but it is the context in which it is sung that denotes the true meaning. The lyrics in this song are not words in any language, but they are based on Aboriginal vocables from the western part of North America. I am a member of the Lil'wat Nation and have sung and composed many songs based on this traditional form."

His statement of context stands out to me. The true meaning of the music comes from us, as we sing and hear it together in time. For this to happen, we are required to open our awareness to that moment. We are invited to listen deeply through the sung sounds into one another's lives and experiences. This community at The Cathedral is setting about to prepare a feast, not only in the near future, but each week, and into a version of ourselves that we can only imagine today. The neuroscientist Lisa Feldman-Barrett describes the impact of sensory awareness on our brains and bodies in her book "How Emotions Are Made." She explains that every action, thought, and feeling we experience happen before we are consciously aware of them. The brain and body have already started the action, thought, or feeling based on past experiences. Our conscious thought tells us we're making a decision, but the decision was

made before we knew about it. Our sensory awareness, however, is the counterbalance to this systemic efficiency. Our senses alert the body/mind to what's happening now, in this moment. Through our senses, we can hope to create new predictions so that in the future, our thoughts, emotions, and actions can be different. Wallace recognizes that in his music intended as communal ceremony. He gives us a sensory-rich space in which to release our predictions and meld with the moment. In this way, we have the opportunity of finding ourselves, and one another as we prepare the feasts to come." -*Dr. David Harris*

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